On 24 August 2010, more than two years after Rahul had spoken out, the environment ministry refused to grant clearances to Vedanta's proposed bauxite mine. The environment minister at the time was Jairam Ramesh, a nominee of Sonia and Rahul Gandhi to the Union Cabinet. An IIT graduate, the silver-haired Ramesh is erudite and intellectual, rare qualities for a Congressman. He is not a traditional politician and has never contested a Lok Sabha election. A man of ideas and policy, not of the masses, he likes to see himself as an old-style Nehruvian liberal. His critics see him as an opportunist. He had worked as a back-room boy in the governments of V.P. Singh, Narasimha Rao, the United Front and even served as an economic adviser to Chandrababu Naidu. His big move up came when he strategized the Congress's 2004 election campaign successfully. He was credited with fashioning the winning slogan—'*Congress Ka Haath, Aam Aadmi Ke Saath*'. During UPA-I, Ramesh was the key member of Sonia Gandhi's National Advisory Council—a clutch of NGOs and public intellectuals who shared a left-of-centre ideology. In UPA-II, Ramesh was given independent charge of the environment and forests ministry.

Tech-savvy, policy-driven, English-speaking, a left-leaning liberal—Jairam perhaps was attractive to a Rahul with similar inclinations. I asked Jairam of his equation with Rahul, and whether he had helped shape his economic and social vision. 'I was not his adviser. Whenever he needed inputs I was there for him. But his ideas were his own in the end,' he says.

One such idea led to the successful setting up of women's self-help groups in Amethi. 'Early on in his political career, I took him to Andhra Pradesh. He met and saw the work being done by self-help groups. Till then, he was sold on microfinance but that visit changed him. So, he was ready to learn all the time,' says Ramesh. A similar experience with the milk cooperative movement in Gujarat saw the setting up of similar milk producing centres in UP.

Ramesh claims that Rahul was driven by a desire to root for the underdog and provide justice to the marginalized. 'All the agitations he supported were driven by the idea that the world needed to be a fairer place, be it in